KNOW YOUR THINKING STYLE

Whenever a situation arises in our lives, we perceive it as either good (for example- meeting a friend) or bad (for example- fighting with a friend). Remember, it is upon us if we consider an event to be good or bad. All these events or situations that take place happen because of a reason or a cause. The way we think about those reasons or the fashion in which we assign reasons to an event define our explanatory style.

These reasons can be explained in terms of three dimensions:

1. 'ME': This defines how we personally feel about our role in a situation.
2. 'TIME': This defines how long will a situation have its effect on us.
3. 'SPACE': This defines how many domains of our lives will a situation have effect on.

(When user clicks on ME)

In a good event

Let us imagine: "You and your friend win a competition that you participated in as a team." You can make any of these conclusions based on the event.

> "*We won this competition because we had worked very hard and deserved to win"*
>
> In this chain of thought you credit yourself and your friend for the win. This is an 'optimistic' style in 'me' aspect because you internalise (consider an internal factor- yourself) the cause of a good event.
>
> "*We won this competition because our opponents did not play very well".*
>
> In this chain of thought you credit your opponent's weakness for your victory. This is a 'pessimistic' style in 'me' aspect because you externalise (consider an external factor- your opponent) the cause of a good event.

In a bad event

Let us imagine: "You and your friend lose a competition that you participated in as a team." You can make any of these conclusions based on the event.

> "*We lost this competition because we lacked coordination and practice. It was entirely our fault*."
>
> In this chain of thought you credit yourself and your friend for your loss. This is an 'pessimistic' style in 'me' aspect because you internalise the cause of a bad event.
>
> *"We lost this competition because our opponents played really well and deserved the win."*
>
> In this chain of thought you credit your opponent's strength for your loss. This is an 'optimistic' style in 'me' aspect because you externalise the cause of a bad event.

(When user clicks on TIME)

In a good event

Let us imagine: "You and your friend win a competition that you participated in as a team." You can make any of these conclusions based on the event.

> *"We always win competitions. We are a strong team."*
>
> In this chain of thought you used words like 'always' which denotes something might happen in the long run. This is an 'optimistic' style in 'time' aspect because you consider a good event to happen most of the times or always.
>
> "*We somehow won this competition because it was our lucky day probably."*
>
> In this chain of thought you used words like 'today', 'somehow' which denotes that something might not happen again. They denote a temporary time period. This is an 'pessimistic' style in 'time' aspect because you consider a good event to happen rarely.

In a bad event

Let us imagine: "You and your friend lose a competition that you participated in as a team." You can make any of these conclusions based on the event.

> "*We somehow lost this competition today. It wasn't our lucky day perhaps."*
>
> In this chain of thought you used words like 'today', 'somehow' which denotes that something might not happen again. They denote a temporary time period. This is an 'optimistic' style in 'time' aspect because you consider a bad event to happen rarely.
>
> *"We always lose competitions. We never win."*
>
> In this chain of thought you used words like 'always' which denotes something might happen in the long run. This is an 'pessimistic' style in 'time' aspect because you consider a bad event to happen most of the times or always.

(When user clicks on SPACE)

In a good event

Let us imagine: "You and your friend win a competition that you participated in as a team." You can make any of these conclusions based on the event.

> "*We work hard at everything we do. We had to win."*
>
> In this chain of thought you used words like 'everything' which denotes that you think you can win any and every competition. This is an 'optimistic' style in 'space' aspect because you consider a good event to happen in most of the situations.
>
> "*We won because we are good at this. Had it been something else, there was no chance."*

In this chain of thought you used words like ‘this’, which denotes that you think you might not win at anything else. It was this specific thing you won at. This is an ‘pessimistic’ style in ‘space’ aspect because you consider a good event to happen only in specific situations.

In a bad event

Let us imagine: “You and your friend lose a competition that you participated in as a team.” You can make any of these conclusions based on the event.

“*We could not win this competition because this is not our forte.”*

In this chain of thought you used words like ‘this’, which denotes that you think you might win at anything else if not this competition. It was this specific thing you lost at. This is an ‘optimistic’ style in ‘space’ aspect because you consider a bad event to happen only in specific situations.

“*We lose in all competitions.”*

In this chain of thought you used words like ‘all’ which denotes that you think you can not win any competition. This is an ‘pessimistic’style in ‘space’ aspect because you consider a bad event to happen in most of the situations.

Based on our explanatory style, each one us can either be ‘Optimistic’ or ‘Pessimistic’.

HOW DOES OUR EXPLANATORY STYLE AFFECT US?

The way we perceive events and relate to its causes affects our mood deeply. If we continue to think in a way (either positively or negatively) we have trained our minds to do so.

If we think in a pessimistic way, we are unknowingly learning to be hopeless and helpless which makes us more vulnerable to depression, anxiety and other mood disorders

On the other hand, thinking positively even when things go wrong will subconsciously train our minds to stay calm.

Our explanatory style is a habit that we have developed (un)knowingly and can be changed for our good.